Resonances of Levinasian Thought: A Reading of Emmanuel Levinas' Basic Philosophical Writings

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Levinas' work *Basic Philosophical Writings* is an anthology of essays, which reflects his fundamental philosophical ideas. Most of these essays were delivered as lectures prior to their publication. The objective of this work is to make readily accessible a representative selection of Emmanuel Levinas' philosophical works to persons who take interest in his thought. Most editors were convinced that this is the best introduction to Levinas' philosophy.

The book is divided into ten chapters. Most of the subtitles contained in this book are expressed in duality or polarity of concepts. This will attempt to underscore the principal points advanced by Levinas in this work by lumping the relevant concepts together in a relatively ordered manner. Central to the discussions would be three general themes: Beyond Ontological Manifestations, From Ontological to the Ethical and The Idea of Infinity.

Beyond Ontological Manifestations

A careful scrutiny of his works, particularly one of his earlier essays *"Is Ontology Fundamental? (1951)"*[1] would reveal that the Levinasian project is an attempt to break away from any form

[1] In addressing this question, Levinas answered in the negative and stressed that ethics is first philosophy. However, this claim was radically refuted by John

• *PHILIPPINIANA SACRA*, Vol. XLII, No. 124 (January-April, 2007) 103-114

of totalization. This occurs when the I limit the other to a set of rational categories, when the I deny the other's otherness or when the other is reduced to the same.[2] As Levinas aptly puts it, "Our relation with the other (autrui) certainly consists in wanting to comprehend him, but this relation overflows comprehension. Not only because knowledge of the other (autrui) requires, outside of all curiosity, also sympathy or love, ways of being distinct from impassible contemplation, but because in our relation with the other (autrui) he does not affect us in terms of a concept.[3] Levinas vigorously asserts that philosophical orientation, in contrast to Western philosophical tradition, should go beyond the self. "Philosophical research in any case, cannot be content with mere reflection on the self or on existence. Reflection offers only the tale of a personal adventure, of a private soul, which returns incessantly to itself, even when it seems to flee itself".[4] This new ontology will give reality a different approach.

Levinas comprehends being as a relation or involvement, not merely an object of intellection. For Levinas," To comprehend a tool is not to look at it but to know how to handle it. To comprehend our situation in reality is not to define it but to find ourselves in an affective disposition. To comprehend being is to exist... To think is no longer to contemplate but to commit oneself, to be engulfed by that which one thinks, to be involved. This is the dramatic event of being-in-the-world"[5]

E. Drabinski. His critique of Levinas is summarized in his article *The Status of the Transcendental.* Philosophy Today 38/2 (1994), 149-158. According to him, Levinas gives no account of the transcendental sense of worldhood and even precludes the possibility of such account. Levinas, he adds, remains philosophically naïve from the perspective of transcendental philosopher, p. 156.

[2] In Levinasian term this connotes violence. Atterton noted that the term violence is rarely used by Levinas to describe the other's relation to the same. When he does, he used it figuratively to describe the sense in which the thought or idea of the other like that of infinity, is inadequate. See Levinas and the Language of Peace. Philosophy Today 36/1 (1992), 159-170.

[3] Emmanuel Levinas, "Basic Philosophical Works," Trans. Adrian T. Peperzak (Bloomington, Indiana: Indiana University Press, 1996) p. 5.

[4] *Ibid.,* p. 10.

[5] *Ibid.,* pp. 3-4.

Phenomenologically, reality as it confronts us takes dual forms. Levinas distinguishes between polar concepts such as enigma and phenomenon, truth of disclosure and truth of testimony, essence and disinterestedness.

In *Enigma and Phenomenon (1965),* Levinas introduces the term neighbor. In relation to the face and its expression, Levinas asks, "Did not a neighbor approach?"[6] With this question, one cannot simply ignore the notion of proximity.

Levinas does not consider the other as a phenomenon (that which appears in the world) but as an interruption or disturbance of it. This is what he referred to as *enigma* in *Otherwise than Being. A phenomenon* is an occurrence, a circumstance or a fact that is perceptible to the senses. An *enigma* is a riddle-something puzzling, ambiguous or inexplicable. Levinas equates enigma to transcendence itself. The enigma, the intervention of meaning which disturbs phenomena but is quite ready to withdraw like an undesirable stranger, unless one hearkens to those footsteps that depart, is transcendence itself.[7] In another passage, he maintains that an enigma is beyond all cognition. Cognition rests on phenomena.[8] Then he goes to explain it in relation to Infinity. Levinas writes, "The enigma comes to us from Illiety. The enigma is the way of the Ab-solute, foreign to cognition. This (is the) extravagant movement of going beyond being or transcendence toward an immemorial antiquity we call the idea of infinity. The infinite is an inassimilable alterity".[9]

Levinas supplements enigma and phenomenon with truth of disclosure and truth of testimony. He presented a stark contrast between these two ideas. Truth, understood in the philosophical tradition is a self-manifestation of being to consciousness, a representational or gathering disclosure of being for which human subjectivity is only a means. Representation carries ontological meanings. For Levinas, this "confession of a subject's experience

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[6] *Ibid.,* p. 69.

[7] *Ibid.,* p. 74.

[8] *Ibid.,* p. 74.

[9] *Ibid.,* p. 75.

or knowledge of this kind is secondary, lower or degraded form of access to truth.[10] A higher level of truth definitely goes beyond the correlation between being and consciousness.

The truth resulting from the subject's engagement in the world and history through labor, cultural creation, and political organization, whereby the subjectivity of the subject shows itself to be humanity, finitude, care for its being thrown in anticipation of its end- this truth remains the truth of disclosed being".[11] This statement is made in reference to Heidegger's ontology.

Levinas likewise reacted against Brentano's view that every psychical act was either a representation or founded on representation; a proclamation of the universality of immanence. He insists that human psychism is not primarily consciousness but rather a relation to the "non-representable; conscience, responsibility for the other".[12] This preconscious relation is primordial or "pre-original" testimony which testifies to the non-representable infinite as that which precedes and surpasses being.[13]

The essay on *Esse and Disinterestedness (1974)* reverberates the same theme. Here, Levinas tries to point out that to be interested is to be a slave of the ego, consumed by its own selfish tendencies. Disinterestedness is the suspension of the essence which is a totalization and thematization. The subject is no longer an ego concerned with its own affairs but a responsible ego who commits himself to the other. It is a relation without a hold on being.

> *Esse is interesse.* Essence is interestednes. Being's interestedness takes dramatic form in egoisms struggling with one another, each against all, in the multiplicity of allergic egoisms which are at war with one another and are thus together. War is the chronicler or the drama of the essence's interestedness.[14]

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[10] *Ibid.*, p. 99.

[11] *Ibid.*

[12] *Ibid.*, p. 107.

[13] *Ibid.*, p. 107.

[14] *Ibid.*, p. 110.

Tallon, in his article writes that the main preoccupation of Levinas has been to describe the event of meaning.[15] He never intended to produce an anthropology or metaphysics, ethical or otherwise but his entire effort is to offer and continuous to reverse in each offering a phenomenology of meaning.[16]

In *Meaning and Sense (1964),* Levinas departed from the notion of meaning conceived as signification and employ "sense", which is beyond linguistic symbolic or cultural signification and is revealed in the emergence of the Other (autrui). He employs ethical language as the most radical step beyond ontology. Levinas asserts that "sense" can be posited only as a movement going outside the identical towards an Other which is absolutely other. Consequently, sense does not arise from need but from desire. It is through this illiety, situated beyond calculation and reciprocities of economy and of the world, that being has sense.

It becomes evident why Levinas can not simply secure subjectivity in the cabinet of consciousness and why it reaches out further to the extra-mental. It is precisely in the level of subjectivity that we come to discover the ethical moment in which the ethical command reveals itself – when the self centered self encounters the other which it wants to enjoy for itself but it cannot for the other refuses to be consumed or assimilated. The presence of the Other in this strange instant becomes a felt weight for me. The face speaks to us directly telling us "I am not yours to be enjoyed. I am absolutely other" or to borrow the words of Levinas "Thou shalt not kill". This was essentially a prelude to his fifth essay titled *Substitution (1968).*[17]

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[15] Andrew Tallon, Emmanuel Levinas and the Problem of Ethical Metaphysics. Philosophy Today 20/1/4 (1976), p. 53.

[16] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Writings, p. 55. This phenomenology of meaning is a phenomenology of the other person. To mean means to be for the other.

[17] Substitution was initially a lecture delivered by Levinas in Brussels before it was sent to publication the following year. In this essay, Levinas introduced into his philosophical writings the notion of substitution, hostage and persecution.

From the Ontological to the Ethical[18]

Two concepts will lead us to a better understanding of ethical responsibility-proximity and substitution. Proximity indicates immediacy with the other person, which demands a response and substitution refers to the act of standing in the place of the Other. In the Levinasian framework, the desire to stand for the other is a result of being held hostage by the other to the depths of one's being where a response precedes any form of rationalization. Craig analyzes proximity as a state of restlessness. For him, "Proximity is not a state or a calm, but precisely restlessness, the loss of one's place, the having no place; it disturbs the peacefulness of the non-ubiquity of that being which constitutes itself as rest in a place.[19]

Levinas noted that the reduction of subjectivity to consciousness dominated Western philosophical thought. He repudiated this claim for this will be incompatible with his notion of proximity. Proximity is irreducible to consciousness and thematization. It is a relationship which cannot be resolved into "images" and exposed. It describes my relationship with my neighbor. It is summoning of myself by the other (autrui), it is a responsibility toward those whom we do not even know. For Levinas, transcendence is only possible when the Other (Autrui) is not initially a fellow human being or the neighbor; but when it is the very distant, when it is the Other, when it is the one with whom initially I have nothing in common, when it is an abstraction.[20] The other, as metaphysically desired is not the same as the bread we eat – the metaphysical desire tends towards something else entirely, toward the absolute other.[21]

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[18] Andrew Tallon distinguishes two sides of the ethical. The ethical is defined positively and negatively. Negatively understood, ethics is the non-cognitive, the realm of element irreducible to representational intentionality. The ethical positively is my responsibility, my subtitution, my condition as persecuted, hostage in relation to my neighbor. Emmanuel Levinas and the Problem of Ethical Metaphysics, p. 56.

[19] Craig R. Vasey. Emmanuel Levinas: From Intentionality to Proximity. Philosophy Today 25/3 (1981), p. 187.

[20] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Works, p. 26.

[21] Enrique Dussel. Sensibility and Otherness. Philosophy Today, 43 (1999), p. 128.

Metaphysical desire is like goodness – the desired does not fulfill it but deepens it.[22]

Consequently, the idea that the person is the his end is abandoned. Levinas says, "the Other (Autrui) is the end, and me, I am a hostage".[23] This does not assume servitude, for the distinction between master and slave presuppose an ego. Substitution arises from the self held hostage by the Other. It manifests other-centeredness. It is recognizing myself in the place of the other, not with a force of conceptual recognition, but in a sense finding myself in the place of the other as hostage for the other. Substitution is the conversion of my being as a subjection *of* the other into a subjection *for* the other. When our eyes meet the face of helpless, and the destitute, we can't help but respond. Dussel calls it an a priori responsibility where it places us in a position of having charge of the victim who unexpectedly appear before us.[24] In that circumstance we have experienced how substitution has taken over the depths of our being.

Levinas relates the concept of proximity to peace. *"Peace and Proximity (1984)"*[25] shows the relevance of face to face relationship with the other to laws and justice. This was his attempt to bridge ethics and politics.

What is apparent in this essay is that Levinas has no intention of dumping political rationality and its claims to universality and justice. His objection is against the establishment of a political order that legitimizes imperialism, colonialism and genocide. He attributed the problem to the attachment of these political systems to the Greek heritage (a totalizing form of politics based on control, domination and power), which he thinks must be complemented by the an ethics of responsibility founded on peace and love.

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[22] *Ibid.*

[23] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Works, p. 94.

[24] Dussel, Sensibility and Otherness, p. 127.

[25] Peace and Proximity is the most recent essay in this collection *"Paix et Proximite"* is unerstood as peace and love. This is sojourn from ethics to politics as he tries to reflect on the burgeoning European Crisis.

The Levinasian project of peace is different from political peace. Levinas explains in the following passages:

> Peace on the basis of the state, which would be a gathering of humans participating in the same ideal truths. Peace which is savored by tranquility that guarantees a solidarity – the exact measure in the reciprocity of services rendered among fellows; the unity of a Whole wherein everyone finds their repose, their place, their seat. Peace as tranquility and repose! Peace as repose among beings well placed or reposing on the underlying solidity of their substance, self-sufficient in their identity or capable of being satisfied and seeking satisfaction.[26]

Seeking truth as ideal, Levinas notes that the conscience of the European is guilty before humanity as it seeks justification of bloody struggles, imperialism, hatred and exploitation, world wars, genocides, the Holocaust, terrorism and atrocious acts in the name of modernity, universalism and imperialism. Levinas laments the wanton destruction of life and life-sustaining environment due to man's selfish quest for political glory. He cites in the following passages:

> "The great empires, which, to such a large extent, decide the destiny of the planet, issue from European politics, economics, science and technology and from their power of expansion. Universalism or imperialism! European empires extending beyond geographical Europe, rivaling one another in power, to the point of preparing – if necessary – to destroy the very earth that bears humanity.... It is here that truth threatens being."[27]

Levinas affirms that the idea of peace is more ancient than knowledge and comes to open itself to the call of truth. Peace would no longer amount to a simple confirmation of human identity in its sequentiality, to its freedom made up of tranquility, to a repose of being founded in itself, in its identity as ego. It could not mean

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[26] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Works, p. 162-3.

[27] *Ibid.*, p. 164.

the *serene calm of the identical*[28] nor *pure rest but as the love of neighbor, an act always placing question this very identity, its limitless freedom and its power.*[29]

The Idea of Infinity

While Heidegger[30] maintains that we live from things through their function as tools and implements, Levinas maintains that we live from these things as nourishments. In *Totality and Infinity (1969),* Levinas extensively analyzes what it means to live from and enjoy. Affectivity in this sense is a tendency toward satisfaction. Levinas admits another kind of affectivity – that which is oriented to transcendence. This leads us to a discussion of Levinas' other essays – *Transcendence and Height* (1962), *God and Philosophy* (1975) and *Transcendence and Intelligibility* (1984).

The affection of the finite by the infinite is a disinterested affectivity or desire. Desire, for Levinas is an aspiration that the desirable animates. An affection which must be described otherwise than as an appearance, otherwise than as a participation in content, or a comprehension. An irreversible affection of the finite by the infinite. A passivity and a patience which are not recuperated in a thematization but in which, as love and fear of God.[31]

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[28] *Ibid.,* p. 165.

[29] *Ibid.,* p. 167.

[30] To engage in a critical dilogue with Heidegger, read more of Ethics or Ontology by Steven Gans discusses Levinas polemic against Heidegger. Some of his considerations would include the question on the primacy of ontology, ontological questioning as naïve presumption, the impersonal I-other relation and ontology as philosophy of power. Philossophy Today 16/2 (1972) pp. 119-121.

D.C. Gates, on the other hand attempted at mediating Heidgger and Levinas particularly on the notion of meaning and mineness and being bound up with the possibility as possibility and certain impossibility. See Ontological Disclosure and Ethical ExposureDarin Crawford Gates' Ontological Disclosure and Ethical Exposure: Heidegger and Levinas on Meaning, Subjectivity and Non-indifference. Philosophy Today. Volume 45/3 (2001), 319-334.

[31] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Works, p. 157.

With the 'death of ontology', the possibility of God-talk is given an impetus by the rise of anthropology and ethics. Levinas, in one of his interviews, relates to us that he does not want to define anything through God because it is the human that he knows.[32] Thus, the ethical relation between persons has become the *camino real* (royal highway) towards God.[33] Castillo claims that the failure of language, of philosophy is not a tragedy for the Transcendent but its veritable triumph.[34] Human language is inadequate. God comes to us through a prophecy which is an existential mode of human existence. The *meaning* found in ethical experience is precisely a reversal of intentionality.[35]

As to the nature of the infinite, Levinas elaborates further in *Transcendence and Height (1962):*

Infinity is the "feature" that immunizes the other against any assimilation or absorption by the Same.[36] The idea of the infinite consists precisely and paradoxically in thinking more than what is thought while nevertheless conserving it in its excessive relation to thought... The infinite is not therefore the correlative of the idea of the infinite as if this idea were an intentionality... The idea of the infinite consists in the impossibility of escaping from responsibility.[37]

This responsibility springs from the core of our being. In the same essay, he tells us that "the structure of this responsibility will

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[32] *Ibid.,* p. 29.

[33] Adorable Castillo, CICM. From Knowledge to Ethics. St. Louis Research Journal. 32/2 (2001), p. 15.

[34] *Ibid.*

[35] Jeffrey Powell. Levinas Representing Husserl on Representation, p. 195. Levinas is indebted to Husserl. In this essay, he underscores four Husserlian themes that appear central to Levinas-passive synthesis, genetic constitution, life-world and history, p. 194.

[36] Levinas, Basic Philosophical Writings, p. 14. *Transcendence and Height* summarizes the opening arguments of *Totality and Infinity* from the epistemological perspective. He regarded idealism and realism as form of monism which reduces the other to the same. This is not possible since the Other is infinite.

[37] *Ibid.,* p. 20.

show how the Other (autrui) in the face, challenges us from the greatest depth and the highest height by opening the very dimension of elevation."[38]

Levinas observes that the rational discourse about God as propagated by Western philosophy, leads to the destruction of transcendence. In *God and Philosophy (1975),* he clarifies his position regarding the movement of the I to God. Levinas writes, "The exposition of the ethical signification of transcendence and of the Infinite beyond being can be worked of beginning with the proximity of the neighbor and my responsibility for the other.... The proximity of a neighbor is my responsibility for him; to approach is to be one's brother's keeper; to be one's brother's keeper is to be his hostage."[39]

In *Meaning and Sense (1964),* Levinas speaks of the other as the trace of Him, of illiety... absolutely past, absolutely transcendent, beyond iconography. Through his prophetic mode of existence, man takes hold of himself and comes to terms with the irreducible other.

> To be in the image of God does not mean to be an icon of God but to find oneself in his trace... He shows himself only by his trace, which is not a sign; it is to go toward the Others who stand in the trace of illiety. It is through this illiety that, situated beyond the calculations and reciprocities of economy and of the world, that being has a sense.

Concluding Note

In the absence of a systematic presentation of Levinas' thought, one may find solace in the underlying "synapses" pulsating in his essays, where the streams of his ideas converge and flows forth throughout the entire corpus of his philosophical writings – the desire for exteriority and liberation from totality, the centrality of transcendence in his thought, the face to face encounter and the primacy of ethics over ontology, the Infinite Other.

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[38] *Ibid.,* p. 17.

[39] *Ibid.,* p. 143.

His radical objections against ontology, which thematizes knowledge and places it in the closet of consciousness is an absolute necessity in order to allow the possibility of transcendence. Levinas chose the ethical encounter as his starting point. The face to face encounter gives the I an ethical command over which it has no power to refuse, to the point of standing for the other in his nakedness, destitution and helplessness- a radical *kenosis* or emptying of the self for the other, *a tearing-away from-oneself-for-the-other.*[40] The subject becomes complete only in relation to the other. This encounter also occasions the transcendence to the Absolute Other, who nourishes the individual with new hungers and challenges him from the greatest depth. It is at this point when we reach a meaningful discourse; where the Said moves to the horizon of the Saying, where the truth of disclosure becomes truth of testimony, where phenomena becomes enigma and where meaning makes sense. ❑

[40] *Ibid.*, p. 102.